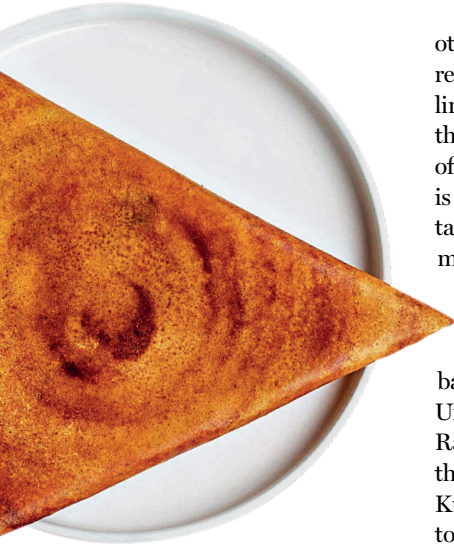
of the Indian diaspora.

Mazumdar and his partners are among a new crop of restaurateurs and chefs who are unapologetic about cooking Indian dishes for Indian tastes. Inadvertently, they've won over non-Indian diners, who have never tasted food like this before. While these restaurants now routinely win coveted awards abroad, it also signals a shift, for Indians, from an obsession with "all things 'foreign'", as Mazumdar puts it. Finally, Indians are starting to move away from the idea that until our food is "noticed by other people... it's not worthy; "we believe it's pedestrian. As if it doesn't require any effort, desire, emotions, artistry".



Roni Mazumdar is acutely self-aware of being part of a transformation in the way the world understands Indian food and diaspora



The food at Semma and other Unapologetic Foods restaurants walks a smart line between novelty and authenticity. For example, one of the most popular dishes is *nathai pirattal*, ginger-tamarind snails served with mini kal dosa, an appetiser that Kumar admits he would likely not be talking about if he were back in India. After joining Unapologetic Foods from Rasa (a California restaurant that won a Michelin star), Kumar "casually" recounted to Mazumdar and chef Chintan Pandya, co-owner of Unapologetic Foods, how as a kid he used to collect snails for the pot. "Roni and Chintan looked at each other and were like, 'This should be on the menu!' I said, 'You both are crazy.' They replied, 'New Yorkers will love this.'" They were right.

It's a different world from a decade or so ago, when Mazumdar opened his first restaurant, Masalawala, as a retirement project for his food-obsessed father. Back then, Indian cuisine abroad was still defined by 'tikka masala', and even Mazumdar had to compromise. It was only when Pandya, an Oberoi-trained chef with an interest in recipe-hunting, joined him that the two found the courage to open the casual restaurant Adda, regional specialist Dhamaka, fried chicken joint Rowdy Rooster, a couple of catering concerns and, most recently, the new Bengal-centric Masalawala in Brooklyn, where rather than *tikka masala* you'll find *bhapa ilish* on the menu. "We'll tell you it has a tonne of bones. If you don't want it, just don't order it," says Mazumdar. "That's what the whole essence of Unapologetic is. I'm sick and tired of apologising as if we're so desperately trying to fit into someone else's mould."

And so there is space at Semma for Kumar's childhood memories of rural Tamil Nadu, and at Adda for Pandya's beloved chilli cheese toast. Interestingly, there's no beef on the menus, and the only pork dish is *doh khleh* (a Khasi specialty made of pig's head) at Dhamaka. But besides the intestines and snails, there's goat neck, goat belly *seekh*, *tabak maaz*, *gurda kapoora*, *bheja fry*, venison, *paya*, *kaleji* and, of course, that bone-in hilsa. And there's plenty for vegetarians, too. "If we're going to talk about food as an expression, then it also comes with a certain level of vulnerability," says Mazumdar. With each restaurant, "we wanted to embrace the heritage of each one of these individuals and have a very clear point of view." Even within India, such pluralistic visions of cuisine in a fine restaurant setting are rare. ■

Sonal Shah



➳ Chai Pani

This "chaat house" in Asheville is the cornerstone of the American South's Indian food juggernaut. The emphasis is on street food and thalis. The eateries in North Carolina and Georgia serve everything from Irani café cuisine, to Carolina barbecue, to piri piri chicken—they even have their own spice company, Spicewalla.

➳ Junoon

After a successful decade in New York (including eight years of being Michelin-starred), this iconic Indian restaurant reopened in a new location last summer.



➳ Ghee



Ghee in Florida lives up to its hearty name, with dishes like yellowfin tuna bhel and short rib dosa on the menu. Its claim to fame is as a farm-to-table phenom, with much of the produce sourced from chef-owner Niven Patel's own two-acre farm.

by Sonal Shah